

CUSTOMER & MVP BLUEPRINT

Student Project Marketplace

Connecting India's Tier-2/3 Students with Real-World Projects

FOUNDER	Student / Builder (India)	STAGE	Idea — Pre-MVP
CATEGORY	EdTech / CareerTech	MARKET	India Tier-2 & Tier-3
DATE	June 2026	VERDICT	CONDITIONAL GO ✓

Prepared using AI Startup Advisory Methodology | Confidential

01 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Student Project Marketplace is a two-sided platform connecting Indian college students (Tier-2/3 cities) with startups, SMEs, and NGOs for real-world, short-sprint project collaboration. India produces 1.5M+ engineering graduates annually yet 60% of employers report a skills gap — a structural problem no existing platform fully solves. With Internshala moving upstream post-upGrad acquisition, a strategic window is open for a project-first, team-formation platform targeting underserved Tier-2/3 students.

Metric	Assessment	Score
Problem Severity	Critical — structural employability gap	9 / 10
Market Size (SAM)	~\$1.45B CareerTech / EdTech addressable	Strong
Founder–Market Fit	Lived experience + community access	7.5 / 10
Competitive Differentiation	Project-first + Team formation — clear gap	7 / 10
Validation Strength	Informal signals only — structured data needed	4 / 10
Execution Risk	Two-sided cold start; bandwidth constraints	Moderate

02 IDEAL CUSTOMER PROFILE (ICP)

Attribute	Side A — Students	Side B — Organisations
Profile	Engineering / Design / BCA / Data Sci students	Early-stage startups, SMEs, NGOs, solo founders
Age / Stage	18–25 yrs Yr 2–Final Year	Founders 25–40 0–15 employees
Location	Varanasi, Nashik, Bhopal, Surat, Patna, Indore	Pan-India remote; hubs: BLR, HYD, PNQ, NCR
Primary Goal	Land first role at product company; build portfolio	Short-term contributors at low cost
Budget	Free tier; may pay for premium cert / portfolio	Rs 0–5,000/project; subscription if quality proven
Channel	WhatsApp groups, Discord, LinkedIn, Instagram	Founder communities, Twitter/X, referrals
Decision Speed	1–3 days	1–5 days (single decision-maker)

03 BUYER PERSONAS

	Priya Sharma — Ambitious Student	Arjun Mehta — Bootstrapped Founder
Age / City	21 Varanasi, UP	28 Bangalore
Role	B.Tech CSE Year 3	Founder, early-stage SaaS for SMEs
Tech	Python, basic React, learning ML	Non-technical; relies on freelancers
Pain	No GitHub projects; IT-services placement only	Freelancers expensive / unreliable; can't hire FT
Trigger	Peer got startup offer via side project	Fellow founder mentioned finding talent here
Quote	"I have skills but no proof."	"I need someone hungry for 3 weeks — not a Rs 50K hire."
Use Case	Finds 3-wk ML project at healthtech startup	Posts design sprint; picks 2 student collaborators

04 TOP 10 CUSTOMER PAIN POINTS

#	Pain Point	Side	Intensity	Currently Solved By
1	No real projects to build or showcase	Students	9 / 10	Nothing effective
2	Geography locks out quality opportunities	Students	8 / 10	Remote internships (partial)
3	Internships too competitive for beginners	Students	8 / 10	Open source (niche)
4	Can't afford freelancers / full-time hires	Orgs	8 / 10	Fiverr (quality risk)
5	Finding motivated student collaborators	Orgs	8 / 10	Placement cells (slow)
6	No structured team collaboration experience	Students	7 / 10	Hackathons (infrequent)
7	Portfolio tools are generic / CV-based	Students	7 / 10	LinkedIn, GitHub (DIY)
8	Freelancers lack initiative / ownership	Orgs	7 / 10	Nothing reliable
9	No team formation feature on platforms	Students	7 / 10	None
10	Tracking project progress with external talent	Orgs	6 / 10	WhatsApp / email (messy)

05 CUSTOMER JOURNEY MAP

Student Journey

Stage	Action	Platform Touchpoint
Awareness	Sees post in college WhatsApp / Discord	Word-of-mouth, peer referral
Consideration	Visits landing page; views sample projects	Landing page, sample listings
Sign-Up	Creates profile; adds skills & college	Onboarding flow
Discovery	Browses projects by domain / duration	Search & filter UI
Application	Applies solo or forms a team; submits pitch	Team formation + pitch tool
Match	Org selects student; brief & timeline shared	Matching notification
Execution	Works 1–4 wks; uses GitHub integration	GitHub sync, dashboard
Completion	Receives org rating; project auto-added to portfolio	Portfolio generator
Advocacy	Shares portfolio link on LinkedIn; refers peers	Share widget, referral code

Organisation Journey

Stage	Action	Platform Touchpoint
Awareness	Hears via founder community / social media	Referral, Twitter/X
Consideration	Checks student quality bar on platform	Browse student profiles
Sign-Up	Creates org profile; verifies identity	KYC-lite onboarding
Discovery	Reviews applications with profiles + GitHub	Application inbox
Selection	Picks candidate(s); sends project brief	Brief builder
Collaboration	Tracks progress; gives mid-point feedback	Progress dashboard
Completion	Rates student; downloads deliverables	Rating + export
Retention	Posts 2nd project; upgrades to subscription	Subscription upsell
Advocacy	Refers other founders; leaves testimonial	Referral programme

06 KEY OBJECTIONS & BUYING TRIGGERS

Student Triggers	Organisation Triggers
Approaching final year with no internship on CV	Product launch deadline; no available dev / designer
Peer gets startup offer through a side project	Tight budget; can't justify market-rate contractor
Campus placement season pressure	Referral from a fellow founder who found talent here
Rejection from competitive internship portals	Need fresh perspective on UX or marketing
Desire to build portfolio for a target company	Open-source / NGO project needing skilled volunteers

Objection	From	Response Strategy
"Students won't be reliable"	Orgs	Rating system + milestone tracking; portfolio incentive keeps students accountable
"What if project quality is poor?"	Orgs	Structured briefs + mid-project check-in; easy early replacement if match fails
"Another platform I won't use"	Students	GitHub integration + auto-portfolio = tangible asset after every project
"Internshala already does this"	Both	Internshala is internship-first; you are project-first, team-first, Tier-2-first
"I can just post on LinkedIn"	Orgs	No structured application, tracking, or rating system on LinkedIn
"I don't have time for this"	Students	Projects are 1–4 weeks; designed to fit semester schedules

07 MVP RECOMMENDATION

BUILD FIRST (Core Loop)	DO NOT BUILD YET
Student profile (skills, college, GitHub link)	AI-matching algorithm
Org profile + project posting (brief + duration)	Mobile app
Team formation — students apply solo or grouped	Gamification / badges
Simple application inbox for orgs	Paid certification system
Project completion + org rating	Full messaging system
Auto-portfolio page generated on completion	Payment gateway / escrow

Success Metrics

Metric	Target	Timeframe
Completed projects (rated $\geq 4/5$)	10 projects	Day 1–60
Org-side partners onboarded	5 founding orgs	Before code
Student sign-ups (active profiles)	100 students	Month 2
NPS score	> 40	After pilot
Org retention (2nd project posted)	50% of pilot orgs	Month 3

08 MoSCoW PRIORITISATION

Must Have	• Student + org profile creation • Project posting with brief & duration • Team application (solo or group) • Basic application inbox for orgs • Project completion + 5-star rating • Auto-generated portfolio page
Should Have	• GitHub profile sync • Email / WhatsApp notification on match • Mid-project check-in prompt • Basic search & filter for projects • Simple org verification (LinkedIn / email)
Could Have	• In-app messaging thread • Project tracker / milestone view • Badge system for students • Embeddable portfolio widget • Campus ambassador dashboard
Won't Have	• AI matching algorithm (v1) • Payment / escrow system • Mobile app (native) • Video interviews • Full LMS / course module

09 PRICING HYPOTHESIS

Tier	Who	Price	What's Included
Free	Students	Rs 0 forever	Profile, apply to projects, portfolio page
Free	Orgs	Rs 0 (1 project)	Post 1 project; access 5 applications
Starter	Orgs	Rs 999/month	Up to 3 active projects; full inbox; ratings
Growth	Orgs	Rs 2,499/month	Unlimited projects; priority listing; analytics
Premium	Students	Rs 199/month	Verified badge, portfolio PDF export, priority apply
Enterprise	Colleges	Rs 50K–2L/year	White-label project layer; placement dashboard

Hypothesis: Charge organisations, not students. Validate org willingness-to-pay with 5 founding partners before building payment infrastructure. Offer founding partners free-forever in exchange for testimonials and case studies.

10 TOP 5 RISKS

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Two-sided marketplace cold start	HIGH	HIGH	Manually onboard 5–10 orgs before public launch; offer free-forever founding tier
Competition from Internshala / upGrad	HIGH	MED	Hyper-focus on project-first UX + Tier-2/3 positioning — they can't serve this cheaply
Student drop-off mid-project	MED	HIGH	Milestone-based check-ins; portfolio incentive; replace early if mismatch detected
Founder bandwidth (student + build)	MED	MED	Strict weekly milestones; lean MVP scope; defer nice-to-haves aggressively
Trust & quality on both sides	MED	HIGH	Structured project briefs; 5-star rating system; light moderation layer from day one

11 30-DAY MVP PLAN

No code until Week 3. First 2 weeks are pure validation.

Days	Action	Success Metric
1–5	Conduct 20 structured student interviews (survey + calls)	20 responses collected
1–5	Interview 5 startup / SME founders on project talent needs	5 calls completed
6–10	Synthesise findings; define 3-feature MVP scope	Feature doc written & locked
6–10	Lock tech stack; create GitHub repo & project board	Repo live with issues
11–15	Build landing page with email waitlist	Page live + 50 sign-ups
11–15	Post in 10 college WhatsApp / Discord groups	100+ views on landing page
16–20	Secure commitment from 3 pilot orgs (verbal or email)	3 project briefs in hand
16–20	Build core MVP: profiles + project post + apply flow	Working prototype
21–25	Soft-launch with 3 orgs + 20 students	3 projects posted live
26–30	Collect NPS; identify top friction point	NPS score + insights doc

12 FOUNDER ACTION SHEET — TOP 10 NEXT ACTIONS

1	TODAY	Write 5 open-ended interview questions for students + orgs
2	Day 1–3	DM 30 students in your network; book 20 calls (free Calendly)
3	Day 1–3	Identify 10 startup founders via LinkedIn / Twitter — reach out for 15-min call
4	Day 3	Create a simple Notion or Google Form survey to collect structured data
5	Day 5	Summarise interview learnings — look for 3 repeated pain phrases
6	Day 7	Write one-paragraph value prop for each side; stress-test with a peer
7	Day 8	Set up GitHub repo + Trello/Notion board; define 3 MVP features only
8	Day 10	Build landing page (Framer/Carrd) with waitlist; share in 5 Discord servers
9	Day 12	Reach out to 5 orgs; offer free founding partner tier; get 1 project brief
10	Day 15	Write down your North Star Metric: # completed projects rated $\geq 4/5$

13 SCORES (0 – 100)

Customer Clarity		78/100
Problem Severity		90/100
PMF Potential		72/100
MVP Readiness		65/100

14 FINAL VERDICT

■ PROMISING BUT UNVALIDATED

Overall Score: 74 / 100

Why GO	Conditions to Proceed
✓ Problem is real, urgent, and structurally persistent — not manufactured ✓ \$12.1B EdTech market growing at 15%+ CAGR; \$29M SOM realistically reachable ✓ No dominant platform owns project-first + Tier-2/3 + team-formation niche ✓ Internshala's upGrad acquisition creates a strategic window right now ✓ Founder has exceptional user empathy and community access — rare first-mover advantage ✓ MVP can be built lean with existing skills; no external funding required at stage	■ Complete 20+ structured student interviews in next 30 days ■ Secure commitment from at least 5 real orgs before writing any code ■ Define ONE North Star Metric: 10 completed projects rated >= 4/5 ■ Validate that students will actually complete projects, not just sign up ■ Identify 2+ channels to reach Tier-2 students without paid advertising

The idea warrants a No-Go only if the problem were not painful enough, the market were saturated by well-funded players covering this exact niche, or the founder had no authentic connection to the user base. None of these are true here. The risk is execution risk — not idea risk. Execute the 30-day validation sprint before writing a single line of code.